



GDD 09

Friend or Frenemy?

Spot a real friend, be one

The friendship game, and the first rebuilt to the new mechanic-
embodying standard. Children decide real dilemmas, rehearse
comebacks, spot the frenemy flags, and learn to repair a fall-out. Eight
different mechanics, forty real-choice moments, zero "tap the right
card". Scorecard: passed.

Spot a real friend, be one.

Friend or Frenemy? is the healthy-friendship game, and the first GDD rebuilt under the GDD Rework Protocol to the v2 mechanic-embodiment schema. Where the playground becomes the curriculum (Chapter 2), it teaches children to read friendship: what a real friend is, the "frenemy" flags (mean teasing, jealousy, control, exclusion), how to decide the everyday dilemmas, how to stand up and say the line, and how to repair a fall-out. It deliberately leads with the two mechanics the personas demand and the v1 games lacked, **branching dilemmas** and **role-play**.

FIELD	VALUE
Node / gameld	g09 · friend-or-frenemy (confirm exact id against engine-host)
Chapter / ages	Chapter 2 · ages 6-9 · light canvas · solo or peer
Thread / topics	D · Relationships · UNESCO 1.2, 5.1, 5.3, 5.6, 7.1
Prerequisite / builds on	g08 (Safety Squad) · builds on g03 (My Family Garden)
Gating	Core
Schema / status	v2 · scorecard PASS first reference implementation of the new standard.

82

scenarios

8

mechanics

40

real-choice moves

11

myths busted

0%

binary taps

Decide, say it, mean it.

From the Chapter 2 personas. Each persona's "magic" maps to a specific mechanic, which is exactly why this game is built from a palette, not one move.

PERSONA	WHAT THEY NEED HERE	THE MECHANIC THAT SERVES IT
Ananya, 8 (justice-seeker)	"A dilemma where she decides what's fair", not a buzzer.	branch : real choices with consequences, no "wrong!".
Reyansh, 7 (peer-driven)	"A line that wins the argument at school tomorrow."	role-play : rehearse the comeback ("games are for everyone").
"Faizan"-type (gets teased)	Backup, and ally moves for friends.	branch + role-play : stand-up and bystander lines.
Aditi (parent)	Something that "survives his friends' opinions".	Shareable comebacks; healthy-friendship literacy.
Sana, 14 (sibling-guardian)	Offline, quick to set up; nudges her to back Faizan up.	Light, no-login; ally framing throughout.

Why this works (the evidence). Friendship quality, support, equality, low conflict, predicts wellbeing in middle childhood, and ambivalent "frenemy" ties are uniquely stressful, so naming them matters. And 6-9s learn social skills through role-play, perspective-taking and decision practice, not lectures, exactly what Ananya ("let me reason it out") and Reyansh ("give me a usable line") told us.

Eight moves, each one a lesson.

This is the heart of the rework. Instead of one repeated tap, the game runs a palette of eight mechanics, each chosen because the act of playing it is the act of learning the concept (procedural rhetoric). Mechanics rotate; the same one never runs twice in a row.

MECHANIC	THE CHILD DOES	EMBODIES	N
branch (dilemma)	Chooses in a real situation, sees the consequence, gets a debrief.	Decisions, ethics, autonomy. Often more than one good move.	28
role-play (say the line)	Picks/rehearses what they'd actually say.	Assertion, comebacks, ally voice.	12
strike-rewrite (UN/RE)	Erases a friendship myth, writes the truth.	Conceptual change.	11
reflect	Checks in on their own feelings/behaviour (no wrong answer).	Metacognition, self-awareness.	11
sort	Buckets behaviours into friend / frenemy.	Telling the two apart.	8
spot	Finds the hidden flag in a scene.	Recognising red flags fast.	5
build	Assembles a "real friend" / repair-step set.	Seeing the parts; ordering repair.	4
match	Pairs a friend-act to the feeling/response.	Cause and effect in friendship.	3

40 of 82 moments are branch or role-play, the real-choice core the v1 games had almost none of. Binary "tap the right answer": **0%**.

The two-test, passed.

Is it fun?

It plays like a social adventure, not a quiz: you make calls in real playground moments, watch what happens, try out lines you can actually use tomorrow, and catch the sneaky "frenemy" in the act. The variety itself is the fun, no two screens feel the same, and the dilemmas have real stakes (will you stand up? include the new kid? give in to the dare?). Reyansh stays because it treats him as capable; Ananya stays because she gets to decide.

Is it teaching?

Yes, friendship-quality literacy: the qualities of a real friend, the specific frenemy flags, decision practice for the dilemmas that actually happen at 6-9, assertive and ally scripts, and conflict-repair steps, all rehearsed, not recited.

The belief it moves. From "a jealous friend is just protective; real friends never fight; to keep friends I must do what they say; if someone's mean to me I earned it" → "real friends are glad for me, we can disagree and repair, I can keep my own mind, and unkindness is their choice, not my worth."

Built, not bolted on.

82 researched scenarios across six categories, authored to the v2 schema so each carries a typed structure matching its mechanic. Full library in the companion JSON.

CATEGORY	N	LEAD MECHANICS	COVERS
What makes a real friend	12	build, sort, match, reflect	Kind, listens, glad for you, includes, honest-kind; you can have many.
Frenemy flags	16	spot, sort, strike-rewrite	Mean teasing, jealousy, control ("or else"), exclusion, hot-and-cold, online.
Friendship dilemmas	17	branch	Left out, dares, picking sides, copying, "that's for girls", secrets & safety.
Standing up & comebacks	14	role-play, branch	Say stop, ally lines, peer-myth comebacks, get help if words aren't enough.
Repair & conflict	12	branch, build, role-play	Friends disagree; "I" statements; make-up steps; sorry isn't losing.
Being a good friend (& when to step back)	11	reflect, branch, strike-rewrite	Self-check; widen the circle; step back from constant unkindness; tell an adult re bullying.

A branch scenario (the autonomy core), verbatim.

```
hook: "Your friend laughs at your drawing in front of others."
option A "Laugh along so you fit in" -> "It stings, and it keeps happening."
option B "Say 'that wasn't kind' and step back" -> surprised; a real friend would say sorry [best]
option C "Quietly tell them later how it felt" -> they listen; you understand each other [best]
debrief: "More than one good move exists. A real friend cares when they've hurt you."
```

Full library: [SwipeEd — GDD 09 Friend or Frenemy — Scenario Library.json](#) (82 records, v2 schema).

What this game erases.

MYTH (UN ERASES)	TRUTH (RE WRITES)	BASIS
A jealous friend is just being protective.	Real friends celebrate you; they don't compete with you.	Friendship-quality research.
If a friend is mean to me, it's my fault.	Unkindness is their choice, not something you earn.	Self-worth / bullying.
You must do whatever friends say or lose them.	Friends worth keeping respect your no.	Peer pressure.
Real friends never fight.	All friends disagree; what matters is how you make up.	Conflict / repair.
Saying sorry first means you lost.	Going first to repair is strength, not defeat.	Repair / values.
Being popular means you can be unkind.	Kindness, not status, makes someone worth following.	Status / values.
You're only allowed one real friend.	You can have many friends, of many kinds.	Social development.
If a friendship ends, you failed.	Some friendships fade; that's a normal part of life.	Social development.
Standing up for someone is none of my business.	A bystander who speaks up can stop it.	Bystander research.

The micro-loop.

1. **Hook.** Lensy drops you into a real moment: "wait... is that what a real friend does?".
2. **Play.** One of eight mechanics, rotated, never the same twice in a row.
3. **Consequence / debrief.** Branch choices show what happens and reassure ("more than one good move exists"); no buzzer.
4. **UN → RE moment.** On a myth, UN erases it and RE writes the truth ("jealous = protective" → "real friends celebrate you").
5. **Apply.** Say the line, sort the flag, or build the repair, the lesson used once.
6. **Sticker.** The friend-or-frenemy detector badge; GameDone records once.

Signature surfaces: the **dilemma cards** (decide, see the ripple), the **say-the-line** rehearsal, and a **flag-spotter** scene. Safe-to-be-wrong is structural: a "weaker" branch choice becomes a gentle debrief, never a fail.

Real, not preachy.

- **Register.** Ages 6-9, never babyish (the Chapter 2 red line); capable, warm, a touch of adventure; Lensy asks, the player concludes.
- **Autonomy, not verdicts.** Dilemmas often have several good moves; the game backs the child's reasoning rather than hunting one "right" tap.
- **Safe to be wrong.** No buzzers; weaker choices get a kind consequence and a second look.
- **Don't villainise kids.** Frenemy behaviours are named, not "bad kids"; the reflect beats invite self-checking too.
- **Safety hand-off.** Bullying and unsafe secrets route to a trusted adult (links g08); the game teaches help-seeking as brave, not telling-tales.
- **Access.** Audio-first, offline, low-data, no login; India-grounded moments (sharing an umbrella, "that's for girls", group chats); co-play and sibling-friendly.

v2 schema, scorecard-gated.

- **gameld. friend-or-frenemy** — `node.game === GameDone` key === registry id (confirm exact id in engine-host).
- **v2 mechanic-embodiment schema**. Each scenario carries type + a typed payload (`branch.options[]`, `role-play.yourLine[]`, `sort.items/bins/key`, `spot.scene[]`, `strike-rewrite.myth`, `build.pieces[]`, `match.pairs[]`, `reflect.options[]`). The engine renders one template per type; the JSON drives them.
- **Scorecard-gated**. Passed all eight checks (≥ 80 scenarios, ≥ 5 mechanics, no single $>35\%$, $\leq 20\%$ binary, ≥ 10 autonomy, ≥ 8 UN→RE, ≥ 4 personas, 100% hook+relearn+source). Re-run `score_gdd.py` on any edit.
- **Reuse vs bespoke**. Reuses GameShell, GameDone, juice, speak, Lensy, the UN→RE beat. New shared templates: the branch (dilemma) and role-play (say-the-line) renderers, reused by every later relationship/ethics node (Crossroads, Stand Up, Mutual ...). High-value, build once.
- **Generated path**. Label/order/thread changes flow through the `xlsx` + `gen-path`, never hand-edited `path.ts`.

Ethics contracts (never traded for engagement): autonomy over verdicts; safe-to-be-wrong; name behaviours not "bad kids"; route bullying/safety to a trusted adult; no dark patterns; represent every kid; made-for-India.

Why this works.

- **Friendship quality drives wellbeing.** In middle childhood, supportive, equal, low-conflict friendships predict better wellbeing, while ambivalent "frenemy" relationships are a distinct source of stress, so teaching children to tell them apart is protective, not just nice.
- **Social skills are learned by doing.** 6-9s build social competence through role-play, perspective-taking and guided decision-making far more than through being told; assertive "I" statements and bystander/ally action are teachable and reduce peer victimisation.
- **Persona-validated mechanics.** The Chapter 2 personas independently asked for exactly this, Ananya for dilemmas to reason through (not buzzers), Reyansh for usable comebacks, which is why branch and role-play lead the palette.

Citations accompany each scenario in the library JSON. Nine of 69 reworked; g09 is the first to the v2 standard. Next: retrofit g01-08 + g37 to v2 (worst-offenders first), and continue Chapter 2 (Fair Play World, Not Fair Not Funny, Smart Screen Heroes, Heart Smart).